



MGT-699-WS_09-14-26

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1. Notes

Action Items / Deadlines

- Check the class roster in the course shell to find your assigned team (sometime in the next week to 10 days).
- Introduce yourself to your assigned teammates (sometime in the next week to 10 days).
- Complete team assignments throughout the semester.
- Complete two individual assignments during the semester.
- Contact the instructor to mediate or resolve truly unworkable team situations.
- **HBR Article / Video Assignment:** Choose an article from Harvard Business Review, a TED talk, or a YouTube video that captures the essence of strategy and is instructive. All six teams must deliver this on December 7th.
- Use AI for all assignments (encouraged by the speaker).
- Figure out how you want to have AI participate in both individual and team assignments.
- Choose a client company (from Apple, Nvidia, or Tesla) for the class project (Project Option Number One).
- Help the selected client craft and/or implement their strategy.
- **Company Strategy Presentation/Project:** Students will select one company (to act as a consulting firm) and are expected to put in approximately 15 to 20 hours of work each to do a good job.
- Presentation length: About 30 minutes long
- Presentation format: One team member or all team members may present in the final presentation
- Company selection: Students may pick another company (other than Apple, NVIDIA, or Tesla) for their presentation
- Presentations: Student presentations take a couple of nights to complete all six, including Q&A, though the logistics for the current semester are still being determined.
- **Final presentation:** 30-minute team presentation requiring hours of preparation time between now and December.
- **Team Collaboration:** Work with teammates and view the instructor as a quiet partner/resource available 24/7 throughout the semester.
- **October 5th:** Submit a book review on *The Art of War* by Sun Tzu (Sun Soon).
- **First Book Review:** Asynchronous assignment where students submit their reviews; the instructor will read submissions and return feedback within 24 hours. The class will not meet synchronously on that Monday night.
- **November 9th:** Date mentioned where the class is not meeting (unless students convince the instructor otherwise) and further background on Machiavelli will be provided closer to that time.
- Individual assignments: October 5th and November 9th



- Harvard Business Review: team presentation, December 7th
- Team project: last two days of class (might be December 7th)
- Short break: may take a short break during the lecture
- Full nine o'clock: may not go the full nine o'clock due to the introductory nature of the night
- Listen carefully to where fellow students work/are located during introductions to help build a diverse professional network.
- **Volunteer for Class Helper Role:** Send an email to the professor (fgluciate@whiteon.net) if interested in being the class assistant (includes a \$25 Amazon gift certificate as appreciation).
- **Next Class Meeting:** Class meets next week on Monday evening.
- Turn on video cameras during class to facilitate communication and camaraderie.
- Connect with the professor and fellow classmates on LinkedIn.
- Take notes on classmates' introductions and roles to begin building a personal network.
- Students interested in serving as the class's go-to liaison (to assist with orchestration, class feedback, and emergency communications in exchange for a \$25 gift certificate) should email the professor at the address listed on the syllabus (fgluciate white on.net [sic]).

Key Concepts

- **Teamwork:** Working in teams provides practice, opportunities to enhance teamwork abilities, and reflects how work is structured in commerce and general enterprises.
- **Team Dynamics:** Teams often include a mix of individuals, where some are laggards and others are more proactive.
- **Use of Talks:** Talks are used in the course because they are fun and articulate concepts better than the instructor can.
- **Deliverables:** Class assignments will be completed with teammates.
- **Course Textbooks/Sources:** Harvard Business Review's "HBR's 10 Must Reads" (Volume 1 and Volume 2 on strategy) is a recommended source for assignments and will be used as the textbook for an international course taught by the speaker.
- **Teammate AI:** AI is part of what everyone works with and can be used for assignments, though it can sometimes be "extraordinarily wrong."
- **AI as an erratic teammate:** AI can be used to remove drudgery in individual and team assignments, but it is untrustworthy/erratic and requires careful monitoring ("pull its leash").
- **M&A Work from Strategic Development:** Mergers and acquisitions work often developed directly out of the strategy work done for large companies, including selling divisions/product lines or acquiring new ones.
- **Developing Complimentary/Supplementary Products or Services:** Strategy must focus on creating value for target companies by offering something that complements or supplements what they already provide.
- **Determining Critical Mass:** Strategy needs to generate enough value to actually "move the needle" for a target company; for instance, creating \$2 million in value is insufficient for a company like Nvidia where individual salaries exceed that amount.
- **Strategy Execution:** A key takeaway of the class is that while crafting or creating a strategy may seem like the easier part, it must be complemented by the ability to execute it; execution is where the strategy becomes valuable and embedded in the enterprise.



- **Use of high-level consulting firms:** Management may retain expensive consulting firms primarily to cover themselves when presenting strategic directions to their board of directors.
- **Strategy Development:** A core process and lifelong activity that involves studying influential strategy thinkers (like Peter Drucker and Michael Porter), though developing the strategy is only one part of the overall process.
- **Executing Strategy:** Involves soft skills such as getting buy-in from teams and communicating effectively to various stakeholders about why the strategy is important and what is in it for them (the "selling perspective" of strategy).
- **Strategy Presentation and Rejection:** Presenting a strategy can face pushback, unexpected setbacks, or loss of buy-in from stakeholders.
- **Applying Strategic/Financial Tools:** Dedicating sufficient time to the assignment helps students understand how to utilize strategic tools and present the financial and economic implications of a strategy.
- **Final presentation project choice:** Teams can choose to focus their final presentation on a project of their choice, including a not-for-profit project, as long as the team agrees and the instructor approves the suggestion.
- **Not-for-profit strategic creation:** Strategic creation for not-for-profits is a "different animal" in some regards, but similar to other projects in others.
- **Graduate School Opportunities:** Using graduate school time and coursework to develop strategies you have always wanted to create.
- **Course deliverables:** Students will have four total deliverables in the course, including a book review.
- **Reading early writers:** The instructor encourages reading early strategic writers because their work remains relevant to strategic planning.
- **Historic strategic thinkers:** Sun Tzu and Machiavelli are identified as two historic strategic thinkers whose influence can be seen in government and enterprise.
- **Labor of love:** academic work is a labor of love
- **Stepping into the academic world:** can be hard to transition into the academic world
- **Why go to graduate school:** virtually all content is obtainable from different sources
- **Value of Graduate School:** Graduate school is worth attending in part because of the network students can build by participating in courses with others.
- **Importance of Building a Diverse Network:** It is essential for individual growth to craft a professional network composed of people with diverse points of view across various topics (from commerce to life and love).
- **Shifting Assumptions and Strategy:** Strategies must shift when the assumptions they are based on change; maintaining the ability to continuously observe, listen, and adapt is vital.
- **Pivoting:** The ability to change direction when conditions change is essential for survival in strategy, management, and life, preventing an enterprise from being overcome by competitors/predators.
- **Class Go-To Person / Helper:** The professor selects a student volunteer to help orchestrate the class, provide feedback on what is working, and receive urgent updates (e.g., travel delays or class cancellations).
- **Value of a Diverse Network:** A broad network provides different perspectives, life advice, and strategic advantages; having a network of people with identical backgrounds leads to an echo chamber.

- **Human/Behavioral Dimension in Strategy:** Despite leveraging AI, databases, and predictive tech for M&A targeting, personal and behavioral elements (such as sending handwritten letters) remain vital in business execution.
- **Roll-Up Strategy in CNC Manufacturing:** Computer numerical control manufacturing is highly fragmented with about 15,000 centers in the US, making it prime for private equity roll-up strategies utilizing advanced technology.
- **Consulting vs. Execution:** Companies can spend tens of millions of dollars on consulting outsourcing studies, but programs ultimately succeed or fail based on execution.
- **Airport Concession Dynamics:** Operating airport retail and food businesses involves navigating complex local politics, municipalities, port authorities, and local departments of aviation.
- **Business Strategy from Operations Background:** Effective business strategies often come from individuals with direct experience in operations, production, and technical aspects, as they understand product practicalities compared to those without hands-on operational experience.
- **Post-Acquisition and Mergers:** Mergers and acquisitions inherently bring change when combining two entities, and anticipating and supporting that change can present new career opportunities.
- **Networking and Word-of-Mouth Hiring:** Well over 90% of jobs are secured through word of mouth and networking rather than standard applications.
- **Execution and Stakeholder Inclusion:** Strategy is ineffective without the ability to execute; the best strategies include the individuals responsible for implementation during development to secure buy-in and practical viability.
- **Balanced Input from Implementers:** While implementers provide critical practical insights, their input must be balanced in moderation because they often operate within a narrow frame rather than seeing the full strategic picture.
- **Opportunity Cost in Strategy:** Choosing one strategic path inherently means forgoing other options, as organizations typically lack the bandwidth or resources to pursue all initiatives simultaneously.
- **Observing and Listening:** Strategy development begins with information seeking, requiring leaders to engage directly with the market and the front-line workers implementing the strategy.
- **Continuous Learning and Underlying Assumptions:** Strategies are built on assumptions; because external market conditions shift, leaders must continuously observe and re-evaluate those foundations.
- **Pivoting:** Organizations must maintain the flexibility to change direction when underlying conditions or assumptions shift in order to survive.

Examples

- **Harvard Business Review (HBR's 10 Must Reads):** Mentioned as a favorite source on strategy (Volume 1 and Volume 2) that provides good material for course assignments and discussions.
- **Healthcare:** Friends in healthcare report that AI occasionally makes life-threatening suggestions.
- **Law:** Friends in law note that first-year students could do a better job than the results generated from some prompts used for case study work.
- **Project Option Number One (The Consulting Firm):** The student team acts as a consulting firm that has been contacted by three world-class client options: Apple, Nvidia, and Tesla.
- **Nvidia Value Threshold:** Creating \$2 million worth of value for a company like Nvidia (or similar companies) does not move the needle because some of their employees earn more than that in salary.



- **High-Cost Strategy Consulting Firms:** References to firms like Bain, McKinsey, and KPMG (APMG), specifically noting an experience with Bain where several million dollars were spent on slides that ultimately stated things the company already knew.
- **Mike Tyson Quote:** The lecturer references Mike Tyson's quote, "everyone has a strategy until you punch them in the mouth," to illustrate a point about strategy.
- Companies chosen by the instructor: Apple, NVIDIA, and Tesla
- Potential project topics: Creating a fictitious consulting firm, analyzing a real-life situation where a strategy was needed but not fully thought through, evaluating an early-stage company whose strategy is not meeting expectations, or participating in a strategic planning process in a current field.
- **Federal Express:** The creator of Federal Express originally presented the idea as a strategy presentation in a class, received a "B" or "C minus" from the professor, and later turned it into a multi-billion dollar enterprise.
- **Students of Machiavelli:**
 - John Kennedy
 - Joseph Stalin ("Jill Stalin")
 - Roy Cohen (subject of the book *American Scoundrel*)
 - YouTube video, Ted talk, reading Machiavelli by oneself (example of what you can't get)
- **Automotive Industry (Ford / General Motors):** Developing a growth strategy around Electric Vehicles (EVs) where a strategy from two years ago quickly becomes outdated because the EV market moves at lightning speed.
- **Non-Business Contexts:** Observing and listening as good hygiene in a marriage or in training a dog; pivoting in sports.
- **Advice to an Expectant Father:** The professor advised a student who showed up to an 8:00 AM class while his wife was in labor to leave immediately, highlighting how diverse life experience in a network yields better strategic life choices.
- **Handwritten Notes in M&A Outreach:** The professor sends handwritten letters on personalized stationery alongside AI/predictive targeting to stand out to business owners bombarded by cold outreach, inspired by a handwritten note received from a political operative.
- **Lucent Consulting Study:** A student (Sean) recalled Lucent spending millions of dollars on an outsourcing study with an external consulting firm (Deloitte), only to pull the plug during execution.
- **Gary Carter Mentorship:** Former Mets catcher Gary Carter provided mentorship to the professor's son when he began his military career.
- **Mid-Autumn Festival:** Celebrated with family to mark the autumn harvest, traditionally featuring mooncakes (a pastry filled with egg yolk).
- **Adoption of Electric Vehicles (EVs) in China:** In Shanghai, roughly 90% of cars are electric, with domestic brands such as BYD rapidly gaining large market share.
- **Corporate Acquisition:** Puig acquired the remaining 50% stake in Spanish skincare company ISDIN (previously a 50-50 split with Esteve) at an estimated \$2.5 billion valuation.
- **Cultural and Workplace Differences (Norway vs. New Jersey):** In Norway, working hours are typically shorter (such as 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM), employees receive extended paid time off (around two months in the summer), and the lifestyle emphasizes active outdoor recreation and endurance sports.
- **1987 Buick Grand National:** Mentioned by the professor as a classic muscle car with primitive mechanics compared to modern vehicles.

- **Disconnect Between Departments:** Marketing executives crafting a product strategy that shop-floor operations cannot manufacture, or sales teams selling products that manufacturing cannot deliver on time.
- **IT Consulting Customization (Andrew's Example):** A development team continuously agreeing to client requests without coder input, resulting in an "out of the box" custom platform that caused severe update and maintenance problems later.
- **Opportunity Cost Trade-offs:** Deciding whether to take one sister or another to senior prom; choosing to target the French market instead of the Colombian market; choosing to manufacture Widget A instead of Widget B.
- **Shifting Market Assumptions:** Automotive manufacturers like Ford or General Motors developing strategies based on the electric vehicle (EV) market, where rapid changes in the market can quickly render a two-year-old strategy obsolete.

Questions Raised

- Can anyone share an experience with McKinsey?
- When did this guy write this book?
- What was he thinking?
- Why is [knowing my enemy, knowing myself] the high form of war, not the sheathed sword?
- What does that imply to competitive activity in an enterprise?
- Do we give enough time to our network?
- Has anyone ever received a handwritten thank-you note, and did it touch them?
- What company has a penguin as its logo? (Answered as Penguin brand).
- Will younger generations' habit of consuming sports through short snippets rather than full games change sports marketing and advertising strategies?
- Where is the American automotive industry going, and what will be the impact of electric vehicles (EVs)?
- What is the current performance level of electric vehicles manufactured in China?
- "What is strategy?"

Definitions

- **Pivot:** A term (borrowed from sports and entrepreneurial literature) for changing direction or strategy when circumstances change.
- **CNC:** Computer numerical controls.
- **Strategy:** A game plan for growing the business, staking out a market position, attracting and pleasing customers, competing successfully, conducting operations, and achieving targeted objectives.
- **Opportunity Cost:** The "road not traveled"; the strategic options or elements that are not implemented because another path was chosen.
- **Pivot:** A term drawn from sports and entrepreneurial literature referring to an enterprise's ability to change course when external circumstances change.



2. Questions & answers

Asked in "Ask about the lecture". Answers are drawn only from this lecture's transcript, notes and slides.

YOU

How many team projects are in this class?

AI · Gemini

Based on the lecture materials, there is **one** team project for the class (referred to as "Project Option Number One, the consulting firm" or the "Final presentation project choice").

YOU

When is that due?

AI · Gemini

Based on the lecture notes, the final team presentation/project is delivered during the **last two days of class**, with **December 7th** noted as the date for the HBR team presentation.



3. Full transcript

Times are minutes:seconds from the start of the recording.

- 00:01 The course is breaking it down. broken out into teams where primarily most of the work is to be done. We assigned you teams and I said we because I work with an assistant day job I'll share with that with you in a minute. You've been assigned a team look in the uh, uh, in the shell and you'll find the class roster and what team we've been assigned. No... need to do it immediately, but sometime in the next week or so.
- 00:35 10 days or so, you may want to introduce yourself to your teammates. because the semester work will be team assignments. There's going to be two individual assignments. The university wants mix in team versus individual and life does the same to us. times we work individually but often we work in teams so Getting practice working with teams is a good thing, inevitably. folks. Some are going to be lagged, some are going to be more proactive.
- 01:10 And it's an opportunity to enhance your team. working ability. If you truly have an unworkable situation, get back to me and... I'll try to mediate or figure out something else, but most of what we do in commerce and even in enterprise. general is team-oriented, almost... Everything in enterprises team-oriented.
- 01:40 There may be a hierarchical team, but the team again is probably a... skill that you want to take with you. We're going to use a lot of... talks because they're fun and they articulate concepts far better than I could. do. We're going to have a bit of class discussion. My friend Andrew was always delightful to have the class discussion. because he's got a perspective that is always unique.
- 02:10 And I'll be relying on you to once again help those class discussions as you did in entrepreneurship class. I'm gonna talk a little bit about two of the assignments you're going to do with your teammates and that'll sort of give you a sense of the deliverables in the class. One of the assignments you're going to do is you're going to choose an An article from Harvard Business Review, perhaps a TED talk or YouTube video.
- 02:40 that gets to the essence of strata. and could be instructed. And that's going to be delivered All six of our teams are going to deliver that on December 7th. December 7th. So you've got a lot of time to work that through but find that class the most rewarding because I certainly absent to school along with most of us that are going to be sharing your presentation.
- 03:10 There's just so much content out there and you can't have too much. a channel to that concept that's there. Um, one of my favorite sources of uh Harvard Business Review is HBR's 10 Must Read. It's a volume one and a volume two, it's on strategy. I will be teaching another course in this area. internationally and I'm going to be using that as the textbook for the class.
- 03:45 So if you, well, you can certainly there's a lot of ways of figuring out how you want to approach that assignment, but Harvard Business Review. gives you some wonderful reads and a lot to talk about. I want to get this off the table... immediately. Every team has as its of teammate AI that is just It's part of what we all work with, and I am encouraging you.
- 04:15 to use AI for all of your assignments. But as all of us know who are users of AI, and I'll tell you my background. I'll tell you how we use AI on a regular basis it's sometimes is extraordinarily wrong. and it's jaw dropping. And those of my friends that are in healthcare talk about the life-threatening suggestions that from time to time come out.



04:45 Those are my friends in law say first she is students could do a better job than some of the prompts that we as the result of some of the prompts we use for some of the case studies. work. So the good news is it is wonderful for so many uses. The bad news is, as you all know, you can't trust it. to take out the drudgery, figure out how you want to have an AI. participate in both your individual assignments and in your team assignments.